

Psychology of Everyday Things

Design of Everyday Things

Philosophy of Everyday* Things?

On Research and *Technologies as Forms of Life*

Rishi Vanukuru

April 6, 2026

About

Today

Discuss ideas across **Design of Everyday Things** and **Technologies as Forms of Life**

Talk a bit about my research along the way

Me

PhD in the ATLAS Institute, 2022 — 2026

Dissertation

**Designing the Everyday Spatial Computer:
Supporting Meaningful Collaboration using Mobile Devices**

Note

These slides are an excerpt of what I used in the class. I also spoke about my dissertation research, which you can find more about here: rishivanukuru.com/defense2026

Good Design

From Donald Norman:

All artificial things are designed.

Good design starts with an understanding of psychology and technology.

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Design is concerned with how things work, how they are controlled, and the nature of the interaction between people and technology. When done well, the results are brilliant, pleasurable products.

Flawed Design?

From Donald Norman:

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Design is concerned with how things work, how they are controlled, and the nature of the interaction between people and technology. When done well, the results are brilliant, pleasurable products. When done badly, the products are unusable, leading to great frustration and irritation. Or they might be usable, but force us to behave the way the product wishes rather than as we wish.

The Promise of Technology

From Donald Norman:

Technology offers the potential to make life easier and more enjoyable; each new technology provides increased benefits. At the same time, added complexities increase our difficulty and frustration with technology. The design problem posed by technological advances is enormous.

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The same technology that simplifies life by providing more functions in each device also complicates life by making the device harder to learn, harder to use. [This is the paradox of technology and the challenge for the designer.](#)

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2. Is the “paradox of technology” merely about the frustration that accompanies its massive promise?

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Philosophy of Technology

From Langdon Winner:

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How technology can “affect the texture of modern life”

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How technology can “affect the texture of modern life”

Engineers appear unaware of any philosophical questions their work might entail.

The scant few who raise important first questions about their technical professions are usually seen by their colleagues as dangerous cranks and radicals.

Technology is Good?

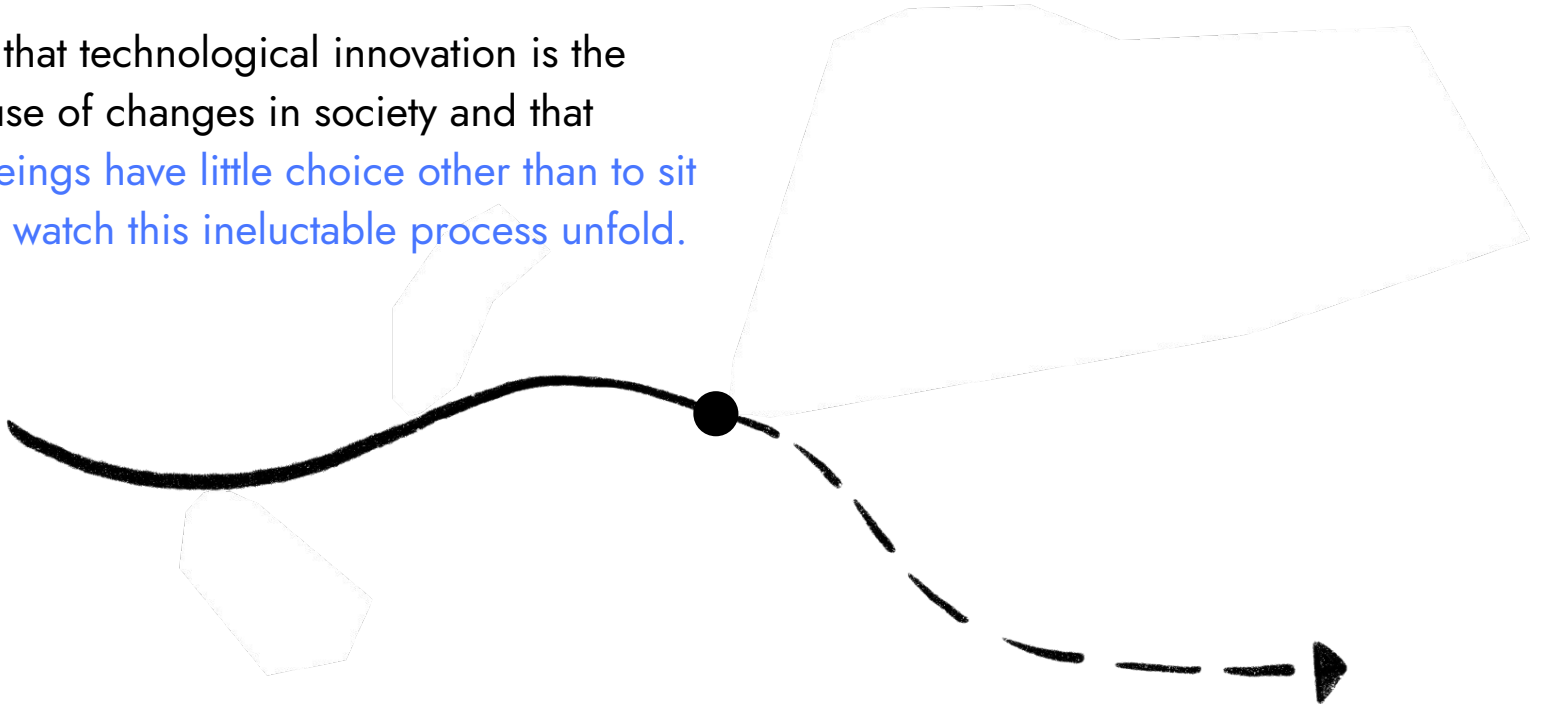
From Langdon Winner:

In the twentieth century it is usually taken for granted that the only reliable sources for improving the human condition stem from new machines, techniques, and chemicals. Even the recurring environmental and social ills that have accompanied technological advancement have rarely dented this faith.

Technological Determinism

From Langdon Winner:

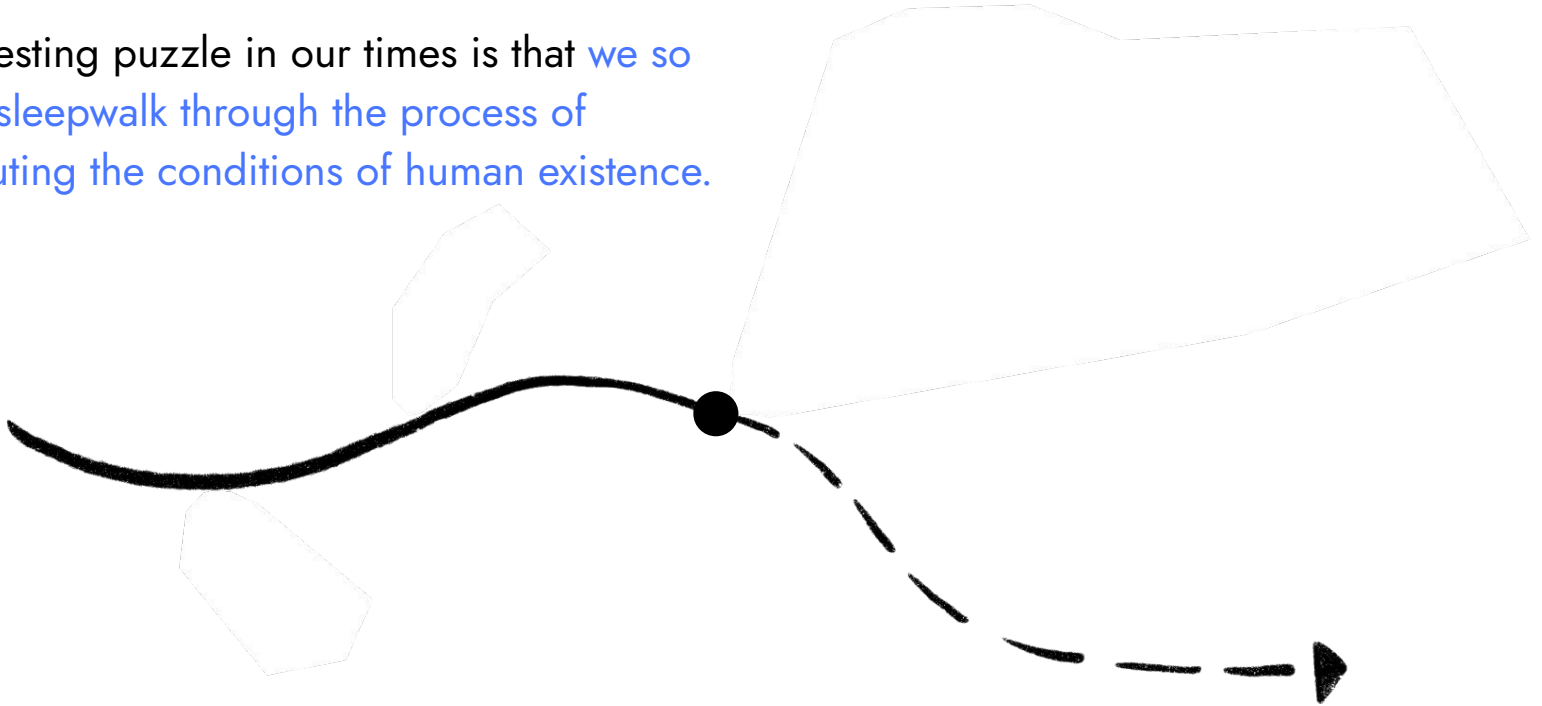
The idea that technological innovation is the basic cause of changes in society and that human beings have little choice other than to sit back and watch this ineluctable process unfold.



Technological Somnambulism

From Langdon Winner:

The interesting puzzle in our times is that we so willingly sleepwalk through the process of reconstituting the conditions of human existence.



Technologies as Ways of Life

From Langdon Winner:

As technologies are being built and put to use, significant alterations in patterns of human activity and human institutions are already taking place. **New worlds are being made.**

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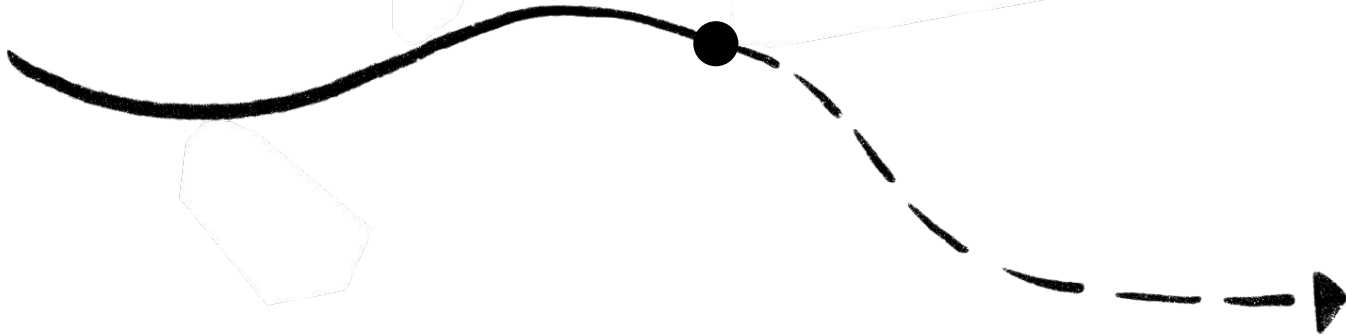
As technologies are being built and put to use, significant alterations in patterns of human activity and human institutions are already taking place. New worlds are being made.

But our world soon becomes one in which telephony, automobility, electric lighting, and **computing are forms of life in the most powerful sense: life would scarcely be thinkable without them.**

Technologies as Ways of Life

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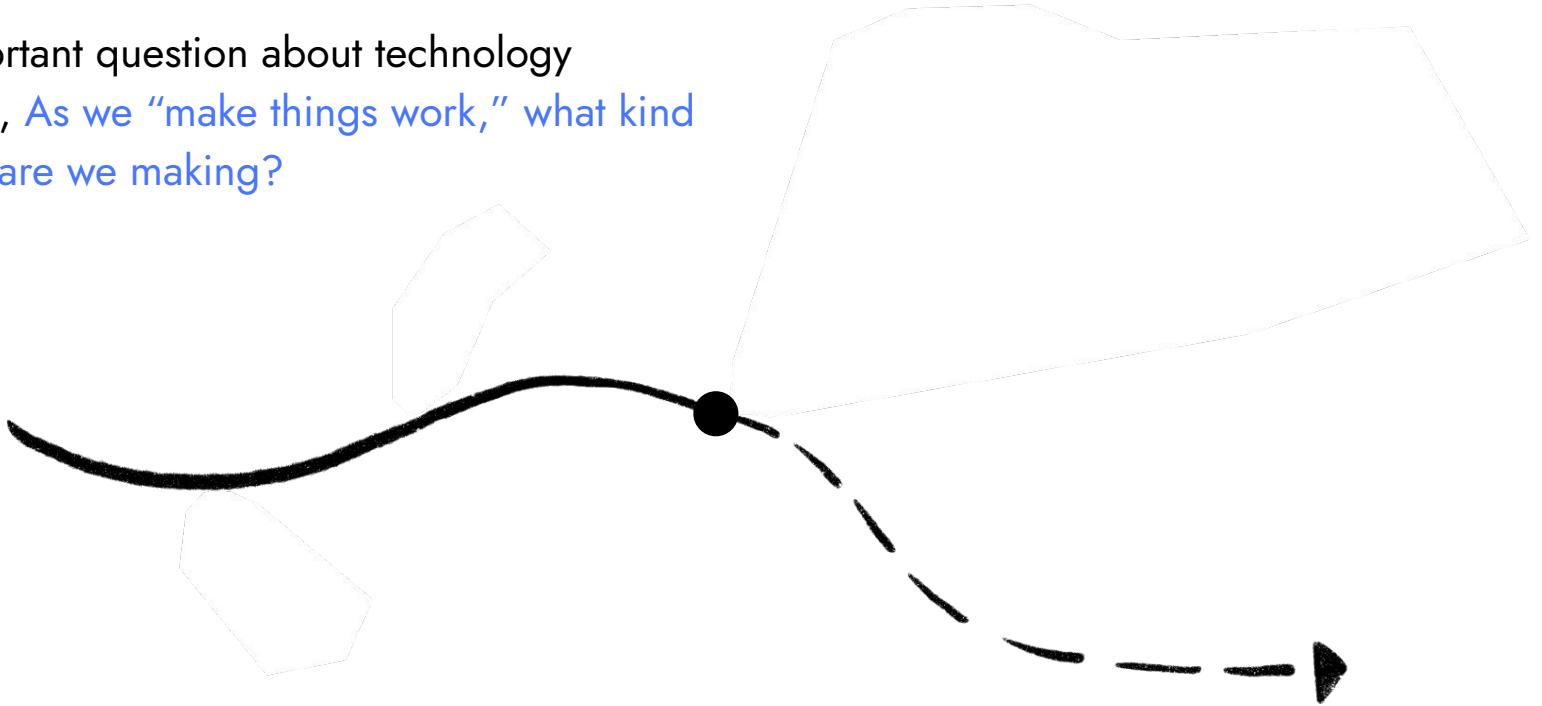
But it seems characteristic of our culture's involvement with technology that we are seldom inclined to examine, discuss, or judge pending innovations with broad, keen awareness of what those changes mean. *In the technical realm we repeatedly enter into a series of social contracts, the terms of which are revealed only after the signing.*



Good Design?

From Langdon Winner:

The important question about technology becomes, *As we “make things work,” what kind of world are we making?*



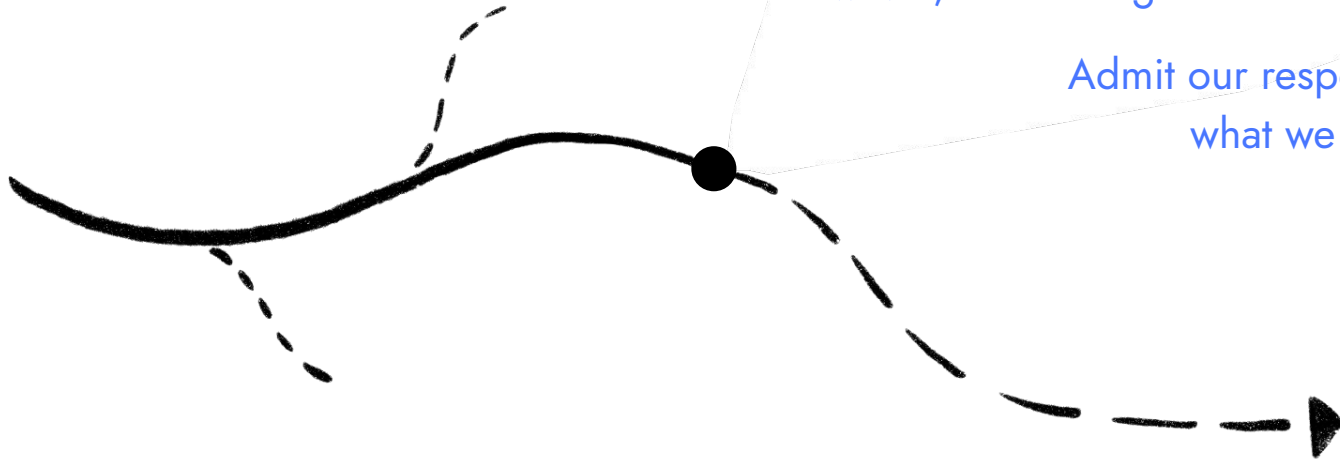
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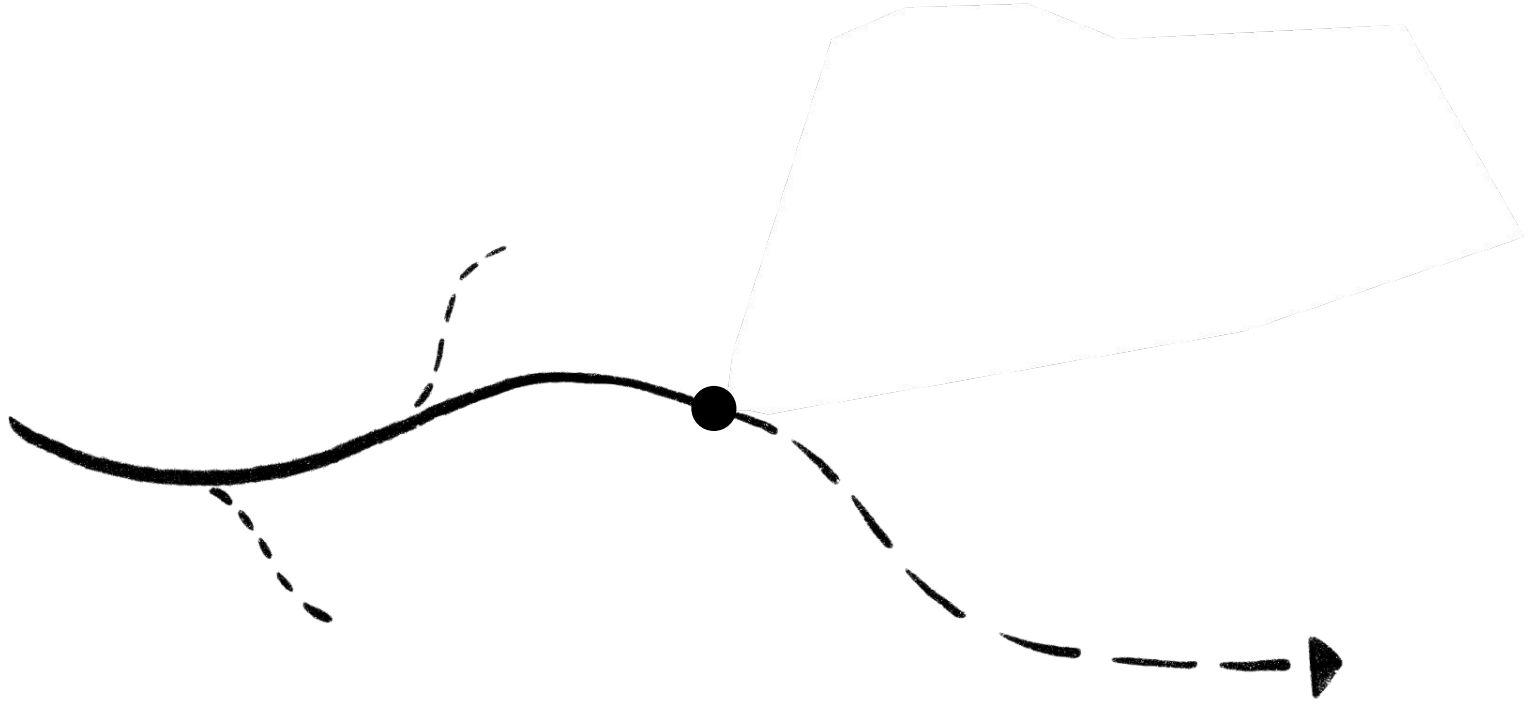
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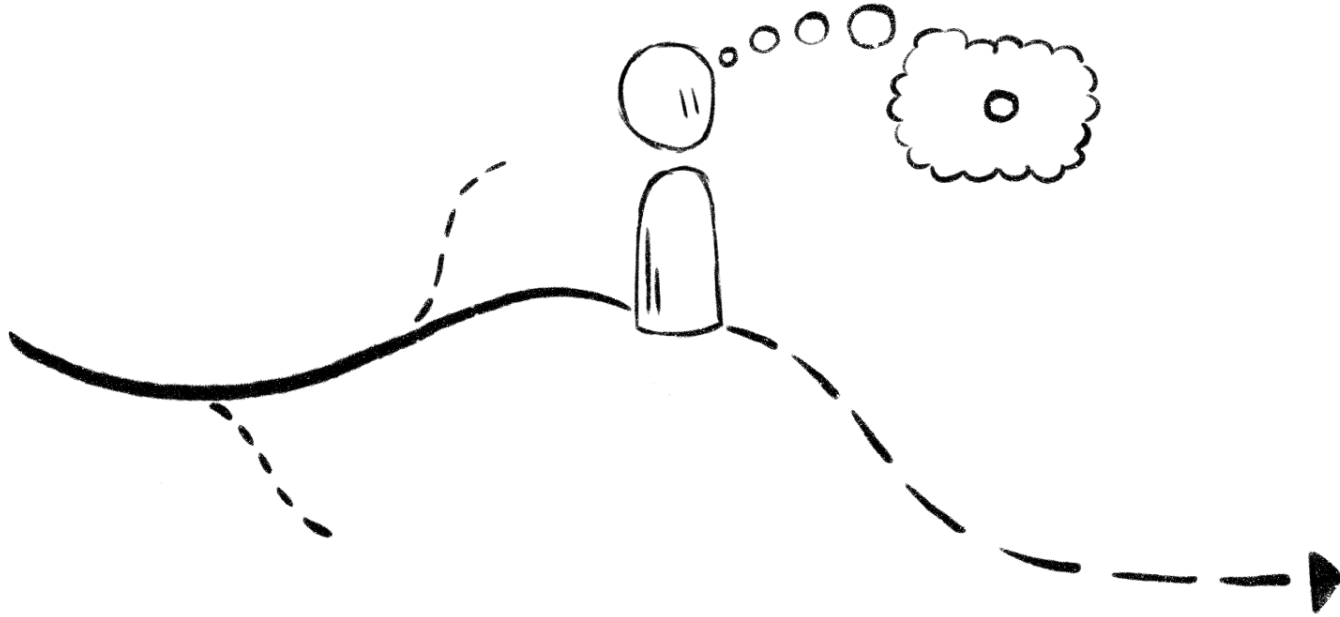
The famous eleventh thesis on Feuerbach:
“The philosophers have only interpreted
the world in various ways; the point,
however, is to change it”

Admit our responsibility for
what we are making.

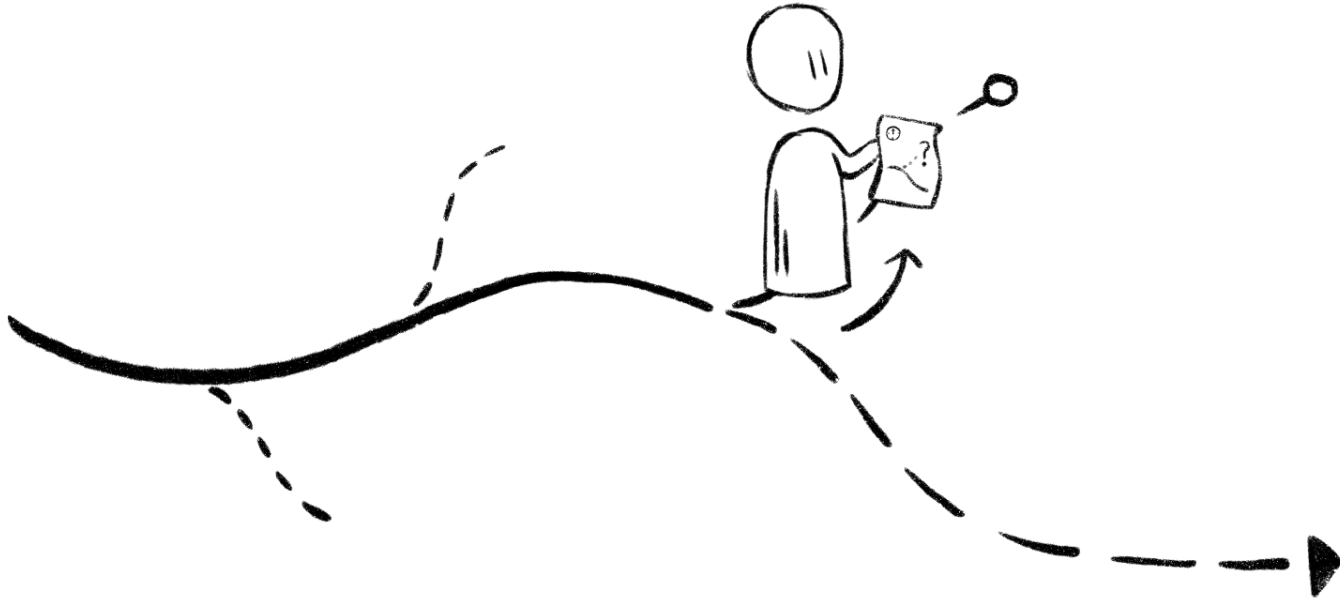




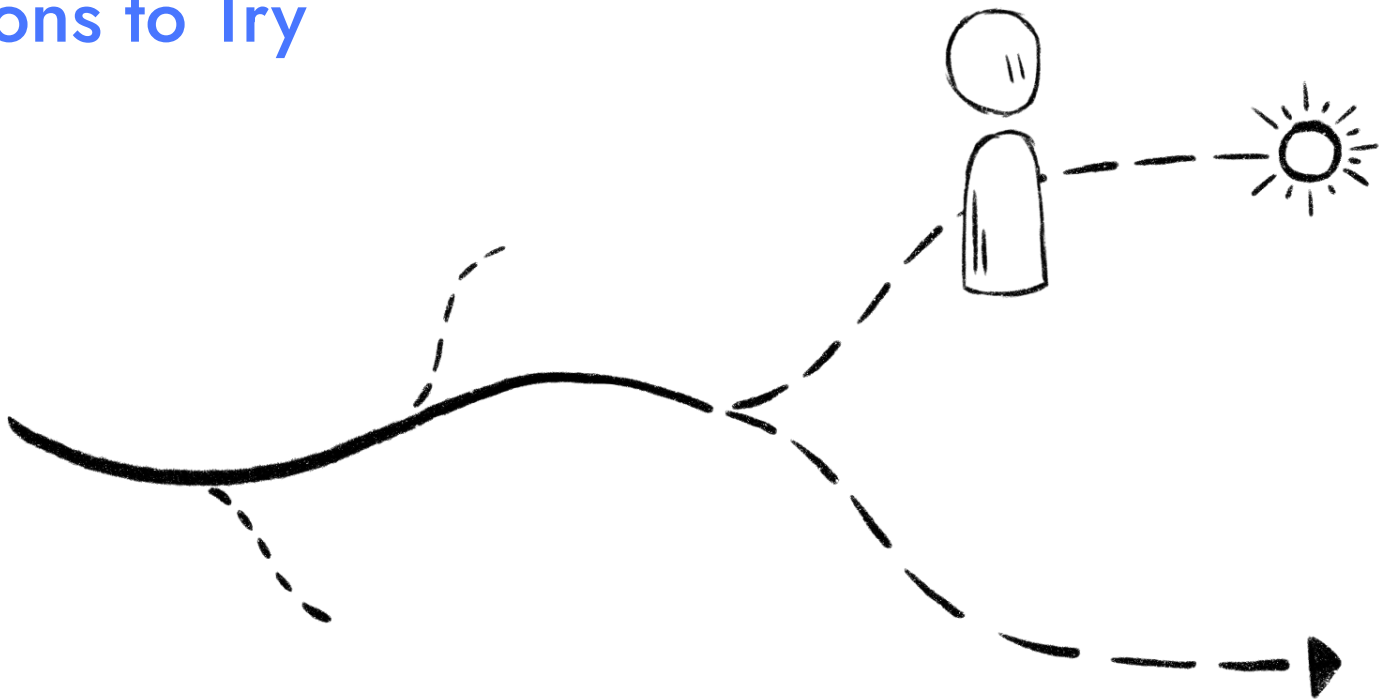
Reasons to Think



Reasons to Turn



Reasons to Try



Countering Technological Somnambulism

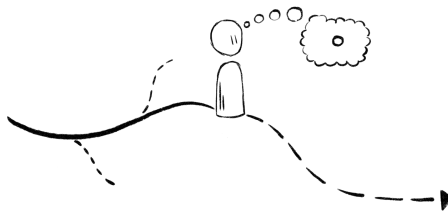
From Langdon Winner:

Social research boldly enters the scene to study the “consequences” of the change. *After the bulldozer has rolled over us, we can pick ourselves up and carefully measure the treadmarks.* Such is the impotent mission of technological “impact” assessment.

Countering Technological Somnambulism

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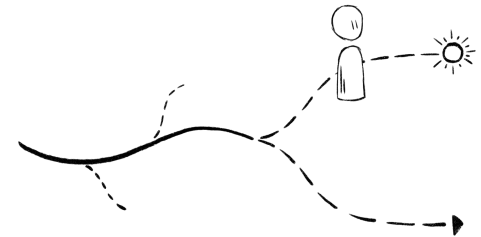
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Reasons to try

Questions for today

1. Should good design be merely about creating “brilliant, pleasurable products”?
2. Is the “paradox of technology” merely about the frustration that accompanies its massive promise?
3. What are examples of technologies that have become ways of life, for better or for worse?
4. What are some examples of Technological Somnambulism today?
5. How did it feel to think about Philosophy? What are your philosophies about technology in your lives?
6. As we “make things work,” what kind of world are we making?

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Thank you!

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